

Sin



A full target, and not one arrow in it. The arrows are in the grass. Missing is the point of the drawing, including the shots we never took.

OPEN PART II BY SAYING

The feast only makes sense if we were starving, and worse than starving. These five weeks tell the truth about sin, death, wrath, judgment, and a real guilty verdict. Do not soften them into low self-esteem. Do not leave the room without pointing at Christ.

Before you gather

- Read Day 5, Sin, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.
- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

What is a rule you broke as a kid that you were sure no one would notice?

Leader. Laugh and move. Do not collect childhood shame stories. That is the devotion's question, and it is already done. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Nobody in this drawing gets a consolation prize for trying. The arrows are not close. Sin is falling short of God's glory — His character — not falling short of the person next to you.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Sin is any failure to conform to the moral law of God in act, attitude, or nature, whether by doing what God forbids or failing to do what He commands.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek hamartia — to miss the mark, to err, to trespass.

MEMORY VERSE · ROMANS 3:23

For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God.

Together, open the flashcard for Sin. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Matthew 5:21–22, 27–28

Jesus moves the target from the act to the heart. The devotion already pressed guilt, Romans 2, and the Pharisee and the tax collector. Stay in the Sermon on the Mount.

You have heard that it was said to those of old, “You shall not murder; and whoever murders will be liable to judgment.” But I say to you that everyone who is angry with his brother will be liable to judgment. You have heard that it was said, “You shall not commit adultery.” But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lustful intent has already committed adultery with her in his heart.

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. According to Jesus, where does the arrow leave the path — only when the act happens, or earlier? **CORE**

Leader. Anger and lust are already off the mark. The heart is in bounds or out of bounds before the hands move.

2. Who is Jesus talking to — obvious criminals, or religious people who thought they were hitting the target?

Leader. Disciples and crowds who knew the commandments. Respectable missing still misses.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. James 4:17 says that knowing the right thing and failing to do it is sin. The drawing has arrows that were never shot. Why is omission harder for us to call sin than a loud failure? **CORE**

Leader. We prosecute what we did. God also names what we withheld: truth, help, worship, justice.

4. Romans 3:23 says we fall short of the glory of God, not of other people. Why do we prefer to grade ourselves on a curve?

Leader. Comparison keeps us feeling like archers. The standard is God's own glory.

5. 1 John 1:8–9 says denying sin is self-deception, and confessing it is the way into fellowship. What makes honest confession feel dangerous in a group like this?

Leader. Image, leadership, family roles. You are not asking anyone to dump a secret tonight. You are asking why the room stays polished.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Sin is missing God's mark in what we do, what we want, and what we fail to do.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Ask a friend far from Jesus what they think is wrong with the world, and listen. Then own one place you miss God's mark — something true, not a cute one — and say that sin is missing that mark in what we do, want, and leave undone, and that Jesus came for sinners.

Leader. Your confession keeps this from sounding like an attack on them. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 • PRAY • 8 MIN

Leave silence between these

1. Ask God to show the group the real target, not a softer one.
2. Confess, in silence, one miss you have renamed as a personality trait.
3. Thank Him that diagnosis is mercy when a Physician is in the room. Do not preach week 19. Just do not leave them in the grass.

Before you stumble

Part II begins. Read the part line at the top before the icebreaker. Watch the shame spiral: some people will over-talk their failures to prove sincerity. Thank them, and remind the room we name sin in order to bring it to Christ, not to perform it. Also watch the minimizer. Both are missing.

WITH STUDENTS

Students hear sin as “the big list.” Have them finish the sentence: “I would never ___, so I’m fine.” Then reread Matthew 5 and ask what Jesus would say back.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

Genesis 3:1–13, if you want the first miss in narrative form. Do not allegory it to death. Ask one question: where do they hide, and from whom?